

Moldova's president plans to send soldiers to Ukraine.

Lucas Rubio, president of the Paektu Institute, comments on the rapprochement between the two countries and how this relationship redefines the organization of international alliances and blocs in the current geopolitical scenario.

At the end of March 2026, during President Aleksandr Lukashenko's first official visit to the Democratic People's Republic of Korea (DPRK), **Belarus and Pyongyang announced a new stage in bilateral relations**. The trip resulted in the signing of a treaty of "friendship and cooperation," as well as the decision to open a Belarusian diplomatic mission in the DPRK and accelerate negotiations to expand contact between companies and citizens of the two countries.

The rapprochement between Minsk and Pyongyang raises questions about how far this relationship can go. Amid rising international tensions and Western sanctions, analysts are also debating **whether the strengthening of these ties signals the formation of an informal bloc among countries seeking to expand their autonomy** in the face of **pressure from the United States and its allies**.

Beyond diplomatic cooperation, the agreements signed by the two governments indicate possibilities for collaboration in trade, agriculture, technology, health, and education. The strengthening of relations also reinforces the political alignment between Belarus and the DPRK **in defense of a more multipolar international order**.

On **Mundioka**, a podcast by **Sputnik Brazil**, Lucas Rubio, a specialist on the Democratic People's Republic of Korea and president of the **Paektu Institute**, explains how the rapprochement between the two countries came about.

Initially, **Rubio sees the Western pressure that both countries suffer as the factor that united Minsk and Pyongyang**. "These two countries are considered pariahs of the international system," says the expert. As he explains, Belarus is not a socialist country, but it has preserved much of the history of the Soviet Union and has a strong connection with Russia, both in culture and in history and interests.

In the case of the DPRK, it is socialist and has a nuclear program that is "very controversial for the Western world." According to Rubio, this process of isolation imposed by sanctions and diplomatic pressure ends up encouraging countries to seek new international alliances.

"When you create this situation of isolating some countries so much, as we see happening with Cuba, Venezuela, and so many

others, these countries tend to reorganize themselves and seek other alliances," he says.

Rubio believes that the recurring criticisms of the political system and electoral processes of both countries are part of this scenario of geopolitical dispute. "These are two countries that suffer this pressure in their internal and external affairs from Western powers, and perhaps the natural path has been this rapprochement."

Above all, countries that do not occupy a central position in the global order tend to seek new approaches based on common interests and greater political autonomy. "Neither Korea nor Belarus are major global powers, so **they will try to reorganize themselves around poles that can represent their interests**," says Rubio.

According to him, both countries share a vision favorable to dialogue, multilateralism, and non-intervention in the internal affairs of other states. The researcher also argues that Belarus and the DPRK maintain strategic relations with powers such as China and Russia without this representing political submission.

" **These are highly independent countries** . People confuse strategic relations with submission, and that's not the case when we talk about Korea and Belarus." For Rubio, the **convergence between foreign policy doctrines and geopolitical events in recent years** helps explain the strengthening of this rapprochement.

Closer ties with Russia and China

Regarding how the news was received by allies, Rubio assesses that Beijing and Moscow viewed the strengthening of relations between Minsk and Pyongyang "**with a certain degree of normalcy**" and **without interfering in the decision of the two governments** .

As he explains, both Russia and China maintain a foreign policy based on non-intervention in the internal affairs of other countries, which would have facilitated this rapprochement. "Understand that this is an internal decision of each government, the Belarusian government and the North Korean government," he states. According to him, given the geopolitical and even ideological circumstances, **both countries "viewed this rapprochement very favorably** . "

Rubio also believes that **Moscow may have acted as a diplomatic bridge between Pyongyang and Minsk** . This is because Belarus did not yet have diplomatic representation in the Democratic People's Republic of Korea, a situation that began to change after Lukashenko's visit to the Asian country in the first half of 2026. "Pyongyang must have gone through Moscow, must have not only consulted, but also requested Moscow's help in the rapprochement," he assesses.

In the **Chinese case**, Rubio highlights that Beijing remains the **DPRK's main economic ally** and values relations with countries considered sovereign and independent. "China is interested in independent and sovereign countries that have an autonomous global role," he points out. According to him, Belarus also **occupies an important strategic position for Beijing**, which helps explain Chinese support for closer ties between the two countries.

The researcher also cites the parade held in Beijing in September 2025, marking the 80th anniversary of the end of World War II in Asia, as a demonstration of the political closeness between China, Russia, Belarus, and the DPRK. On that occasion, Xi Jinping positioned Kim Jong-un and Lukashenko beside him during the ceremony, while Vladimir Putin occupied the other side of the Chinese leader.

"These four capitals, Minsk, Beijing, Moscow, and Pyongyang, are actually operating on a very close line."

Changing relationships

Another point addressed is how the relationship between Belarus and the DPRK alters **how countries should think about organizing alliances and relationships on the international stage**. As a way to avoid being cornered and attacked, Rubio emphasizes that these countries are forming international alliances and blocs without taking into account cultural, geographical, or historical differences.

"Countries observe the world in flux, and they too are following a flow," says the expert. According to him, governments considered frequent targets of Western pressure understand that they need to build new forms of cooperation **to avoid political, economic, and even military isolation**.

"If they don't reorganize, they are the next targets," he points out.

According to him, countries previously portrayed as "villains" by the media and Western discourse have come to be viewed differently by a significant part of the world. The researcher cites the case of China, seen as

a **benchmark in technological development and the fight against poverty**; and Russia, which, despite the sanctions imposed, **maintained and expanded relations with other countries outside the Western axis**.

In this context, Belarus and the DPRK would see mutual advantages in deepening relations precisely because they share similar experiences of sanctions and isolation. "There are so many sanctions that you find in your sanctioned partners the option of circumventing these sanctions," says Rubio.